

**WazirX NFT Marketplace**

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WazirX

NFT marketplace

India's leading crypto exchange has announced the launch of the first NFT marketplace for local artists

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WazirX is an incredibly easy to use cryptocurrency trading platform, with a rapid onboarding process with integrated AI. Since its launch in 2018, WazirX has grown rapidly to become India's largest trading platform. When it comes to distributed ledger technologies, NFTs are all the rage right now, as regular readers of our magazine will know. The exchange has now announced a platform for NFT artists, where local creators will be able to sell their art in the digital marketplace. We spoke to Nischal Shetty, Founder, WazirX to understand more about the platform and the launch.

"We are a crypto exchange, where we provide the technology platform for anyone to buy and sell cryptocurrencies. In 2017, the Bitcoin prices were going up and I tried to use some of the existing exchanges back then in India. It took me about three or five days to buy my first Bitcoin, by which time the prices had shot up. Then I realised that the products are also not up to the mark in

comparison to global products, in terms of ease of use, user experience, the liquidity was less in the Indian market and people were also paying more than the international prices. All of this led to me deciding that a crypto exchange that will be idea for India because there are a lot of gaps in the market. The biggest I saw was that, back then, I could just google and go for whatever exchange came up, I wouldn't know the background of the founders, or who it was, so it was very difficult to trust what exchange to go for. In an unregulated market, trust is very important because there are no licenses in an unregulated market. That is one of the reasons I took charge of the whole trust building in the market, and as a founder I am very and involved with the community. We announced that we were launching in 2018, and we saw forty thousand people signing up even before we launched. The market showed that there is a demand for an exchange that is simple to use, and where the founders are publicly communicating with the users."

Transparency is built into the product as a feature. WazirX publishes regular blogs on the crypto industry, has a newsletter for updates, and all the details about how the platform works is available easily to the users in a format that is easy to understand. Since launch, the platform has been evolving rapidly, rolling out features as quickly as there is a demand for it. Since NFTs are a hot thing now, WazirX rolled out an NFT marketplace for local artists. "We have been growing

really fast and today we are the largest (exchange) in the Industry. We have been listening to what the users want since the early days. Based on the number of people who are interested we take decisions on what to build for, we go about it that way. NFT is yet another example of that where we saw a lot of our users asking for a way to buy NFTs through an Indian platform. If you see globally, the NFT sector is heating up, where a lot of large artists are launching their own tokens. Now the New York Stock Exchange is launching its token of listed companies. So there is a lot of demand which is what led us to announce the launch (of the NFT marketplace)."

NFT tokens are "minted" as a transaction on the underlying blockchain, where a permanent record of it is saved. The unique token on the blockchain is mapped to a file, which subsequently cannot be altered or tampered. The artist has to pay a price for interacting with the blockchain, for example, there is a gas cost for minting an NFT on the ethereum blockchain. WazirX has indicated that it plans to reduce the cost associated with minting an NFT for the artist, and if possible get rid of it altogether.

Shetty tells us, "the thing with NFT is that you could attach any media to it, which could be an image file, can be an audio file, or a video file. The way artists can really get involved is by minting originals of their work, as an NFT token. Let's say you are a musician, you could then sell an original rendition of your music to anyone who wants to buy it. This is just an example the fan bases of influencers, youtubers, instagrammers and creators can get involved by buying the NFTs. This is a great way for fans to support the work of these artists, and at the same time if the artists grow bigger in the future then the prices of these NFTs will appreciate, thus helping these early backers benefit from the growth of the artist. So it is a sort of a win win for both